

Working title: Arcade Shooter

Concept Statement: A retro, fast paced 2D horde shooter with one arena, endless waves and one life. Survive as long as possible and get a highscore.

Genre: Arcade, Horde Shooter

Target Audience: Everyone. A player should understand the game within ten seconds of watching someone else play it.

Unique Selling Points:

1. **Move or Shoot (never both)** - Holding fire roots player in one position making them vulnerable. Shooting costs mobility.
2. **Ultimate you're rewarded for hoarding.** - Kills drop coins that charge powerful ultimate. When ultimate is fully charged, coins are converted to points. You can use powerful ability or farm the score.
3. **Powerful power ups that leave a mark** - Each pickup gives a strong temporary boost, and leaves a smaller permanent one for the rest of the run so the player gets visibly powerful in longer runs.

Player Experience, Game POV:

Fixed top down camera with entire arena visible at once. The player should never lose information, only options.

The intended feeling is rising pressure, punctuated by relief. Constant tension of choosing when to stop moving and commit to a shot, released by a well timed shockwave ability or lucky powerup.

Runs should last between 2 to 10 minutes and restart infinitely, failure should be cheap and "one more try" is the default reaction.

Visual and Audio Style:

Flat geometric shapes on a dark floor. Colors and silhouette should be instantly readable.

Postprocessing includes lots of bloom, chromatic aberration to give an arcade-y feeling.

Feedback from player actions has to reflect through game audio and visuals like screen shake, hit flashes, floating damage numbers etc.

Audio is information, distinct audio effects should communicate the current state of the game and every important action should have an audio cue. Gameplay music should slow-down on player death similarly to balatro.

Platform, Technology, Scope:

Primary target: Arcade cabinet (one joystick and 6 buttons)

Content target: 1 level, ~3 weapons, ~3 enemy types, ~3 power-ups, ~2 ultimates.

Out of scope: Multiplayer, Procedural Levels, Narrative, Unlock progression beyond high score and limited statistics.

Core Loops:

Assess situation -> Reposition -> Stop & Shoot -> Collect coins

Survive wave -> Pick up power ups, ability -> Spend ultimate -> Next Wave (harder)

Objectives and Progression:

There's no winning state. The objective is to survive as long as possible and score highest, dying is expected at the end of every run.

- Difficulty scales with time survived. (Spawn rate, Enemy speed, Enemy Health, Enemy projectiles)
- New enemies unlock with time.
- Wave structure: fixed spawn phase -> clear wave -> short break with a health pickup
- High score and total statistics (enemies killed, kills by type, time played etc.) are saved between sessions.

Game Systems:

Spawn "director" - randomly choose enemy spawns, show a warning marker and spawn a cluster of enemies.

Difficulty manager - Game scales with time.

Weapons - SO driven for fast iteration and expansion.

Power ups - Timed big boost with a permanent smaller residue.

Coin economy - Kills drop coins -> charge the ultimate -> surplus converts to score

Score/Stats - Run score, High score, lifetime statistics

Feedback layer - Screen effects, announcements, telegraphed spawns and audio cues.

Milestones:

1 Playable core / MVP:

Arena, player movement, move or shoot control scheme, one weapon, one chasing enemy, health, death. Done when run can be started and lost.

2 Actual Game:

Wave system, Difficulty scaling, all enemy types, all weapons, all power-ups, all abilities, coins, working HUD. Done when a full run has a beginning, middle and difficulty spike that eventually kills you.

3 Feel:

Juice pass - shake, hit-stops, flashes, popups, full audio, menus with stats and pause. Done when published to github pages and playable by external players.